
Painting for Profit and Pleasure: Angelica Kauffman and the Art Business in Rome

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3. Krzysztof Pomian, *Collectors and Curiosities, Paris and Venice, 1500–1800*, trans. by Elizabeth Wiles-Porter (Cambridge: Polity Press, 1990).
4. Annie Becq, “Expositions, peintres et critiques: Vers l’image moderne de l’artiste,” *Dix-huitième Siècle* 14 (1982): 131–48.
5. Cynthia J. Koepp, “The Alphabetical Order: Work in Diderot’s *Encyclopédie*,” in Steven Laurence Kaplan & Cynthia J. Koepp, eds., *Work in France, Representations, Meaning, Organization and Practice* (Ithaca, N.Y.: Cornell Univ. Press, 1986), 229–57.
6. The citation and a reproduction of a drawing after the picture by Robert is in G. Henriot, *Collection David-Weill* (Paris: Des Presses De Braun, 1928), 3: 371–72. Both paintings have traditionally been taken as representations of Robert’s family. A drawing of the servant-and-child image is in the Pierpont Morgan Library.
7. Annie Becq, “Creation, Aesthetics, Market: Origins of the Modern Concept of Art,” in Paul Mattick Jr., ed., *Eighteenth-Century Aesthetics and the Reconstruction of Art* (Cambridge: Cambridge Univ. Press, 1993), 240–54.
8. For example, see Elisabeth Vigée-Lebrun’s portrait of Robert, Salon of 1789, which configures him in the iconography of genius; also Jacques Delille’s chilling account in the poem *imagination* (1806) of the man lost in the catacombs that alludes to an experience of Hubert Robert.

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In April 1786 Hester Lynch Piozzi wrote from Italy: “I must not quit Rome, however, without a word of Angelica Kauffman, who, though neither English nor Italian, has contrived to charm both nations, and her superior talents, both here and there. Besides her painting for which the world has been the judge, her conversation attract all people of taste to her house, which none can bear to leave without difficulty and regret.”¹ By the time of this visit to Rome, Kauffman was indeed at the height of her fame, well established as one of the stars of the international community in that city. Her studio had become a popular stop on the Grand Tour for fashionable visitors, dealers, painters, poets, and princes from all over Europe and Britain who wished to have their portraits made, to commission history paintings, or simply to participate in the evenings of conversation, poetry reading, and music with Kauffman and her husband, Antonio Zucchi, with whom she had settled in Rome in 1782.²

Throughout her career in Rome Kauffman earned a steady flow of income from works which ranged from large paintings to decorative engravings, and the sheer volume as well as the variety of Kauffman’s artistic output is notable. The purpose of this paper is to explore Kauffman’s attitude towards her work—work which brought so much delight to her clients and profit to herself—through a study of the house in which she lived, some examples of her artistic production, and the comments of her friends.

Soon after their arrival in Rome Kauffman and Zucchi moved into a large house on the via Sistina, and in the following years they spent lavish sums on furniture, china, silver, linens, carriages and horses, books and paintings, all the accoutrements of fashionable life in Rome.³ The house was entered through a large hall filled with plaster figures of well-known classical statues, followed by the major reception room which displayed, along with other works of art, an impressive collection of bound prints of Roman antiquities and engravings after the paintings of important Renaissance and seventeenth-century artists.⁴ In 1805 a German visitor claimed that Kauffman’s house virtually “breathed Art.” In the Salon he noted, “her portrait made by Reynolds in London “hung between two beautiful heads by Van Dyck and Rembrandt.”⁵ The “Rembrandt” was actually Kauffman’s own youthful copy made after his self-portrait in Florence, a painting that must have held special significance, for she kept this picture with her all

her life.⁶ Kauffman's Salon, with its classical statuary, ornately framed paintings, and fine books, provided an appropriate setting for a woman of taste, intellect, and artistic pursuits. Her portrait by the noted English painter Reynolds between her own copy of Rembrandt's self-portrait and one by Van Dyck connected her as both image and artist with that masculine world of the great portrait painters of past and present. This was a suite of rooms calculated to impress and would have fulfilled the expectations of potential clients. In contrast to the formality of the reception rooms, Kauffman's studio at the opposite end of the house, the site where she practiced her art, was cluttered with easels, palettes, brushes, stones for grinding pigments, jars of oil, mannequins, mirrored lamps, a pocket lens, and numerous other tools of the painter's trade.⁷

Three portraits all made in 1793 can serve to illustrate the variety of Kauffman's clients and her talent for flattering depictions that made her work seem easy. A half-length portrait of the novelist *Cornelia Knight* (Manchester, City Art Gallery, 37 3/4 x 31 1/2 in.) painted "par amicitia," out of friendship, shows her with several of her books and a pencil, for, as noted in by Kauffman, she loved to draw.⁸ A cameo at her waist bears a profile portrait of Kauffman added at the request of Lady Knight, the sitter's mother. A much larger full-length portrait of the Second Lord Berwick (National Trust, Attingham Park, 86 1/2" x 56 1/2") on the Grand Tour, represents him attired as an elegant aristocrat in fancy Van Dyck dress, seated beside one of the most notable antiquities in Rome, the Medici vase.⁹ The Irishman *David Ker* (David Ker collection, England, approx. 47 x 39 1/2 in., fig. 1), although described in her "Memorandum of Paintings" as a "nobleman," was neither an aristocrat nor a distinguished intellectual.¹⁰ Nevertheless, Kauffman portrayed him just after his arrival in Rome in a reflective, classical pose at a library table in front of a distant view of the Coliseum. On the table are Pliny's *Natural History* and a volume of Milton, and the open book reveals its title across the top of the pages: "On the Human Understanding," most likely meant as John Locke's essay. A small statue in the style of Canova represents Roman charity, a woman suckling her dying father. This eclectic group of items lends Ker the aura of a man of deep thought and virtue, a beloved father, well versed in the classics, political philosophy, and natural history. Such a portrait by the celebrated Kauffman would establish him as a tasteful gentleman of means surrounded by the appropriate trappings of a sophisticated British resident in Rome. Soon after it was completed, Ker wrote to his brother with enthusiasm about his purchases of old master paintings and a Stradivarius violin reputed to have been made for the Duke of Tuscany and bought on the advice of no less a person than Angelica Kauffman. One can easily imagine Ker posing for his portrait while enjoying conversation with the knowledgeable and attractive artist. But how can we imagine how the artist Kauffman may have felt, hard at work on the other side of the easel?

In 1787 Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, who was then resident in Rome, wrote about a Sunday afternoon visit to the Aldobrandini collection with Kauffman: "She is not as happy as she deserves to be, in view of her truly great talent and daily increasing wealth. She is tired of painting pictures to sell, and yet her old husband delights in seeing such big money coming in for what is often little work. She would like to work for her own pleasure, with greater leisure, care, and study; and she could do this. They have no children, they cannot use up the interest on their investments, and every day, even without working very hard, she earns another sizable amount. But that is not how it is, and it never will be. She talks very candidly with me, I have told her my opinion, given her my advice, and encourage her whenever I am with her."¹¹

Goethe's concern for Kauffman suggests an overly Romantic assessment of her situation, putting the blame for her hard work and busy schedule on her avaricious husband. Another friend, the poet Johann Gottfried Herder, also believed she suffered from Zucchi's greed and lived a lonely, childless life; yet he wrote in 1789 that "she is by profession a man, and has done more than fifty men could have and would have done in the same time."¹² It seems as if Goethe and Herder could not reconcile their idea of this feminine, modest, albeit clever and talented woman taking satisfaction in hard work and financial gain driven by her own ambition. Naturally, they would have preferred that she spend more leisure time with them as companion and guide to the artistic sites of Rome.

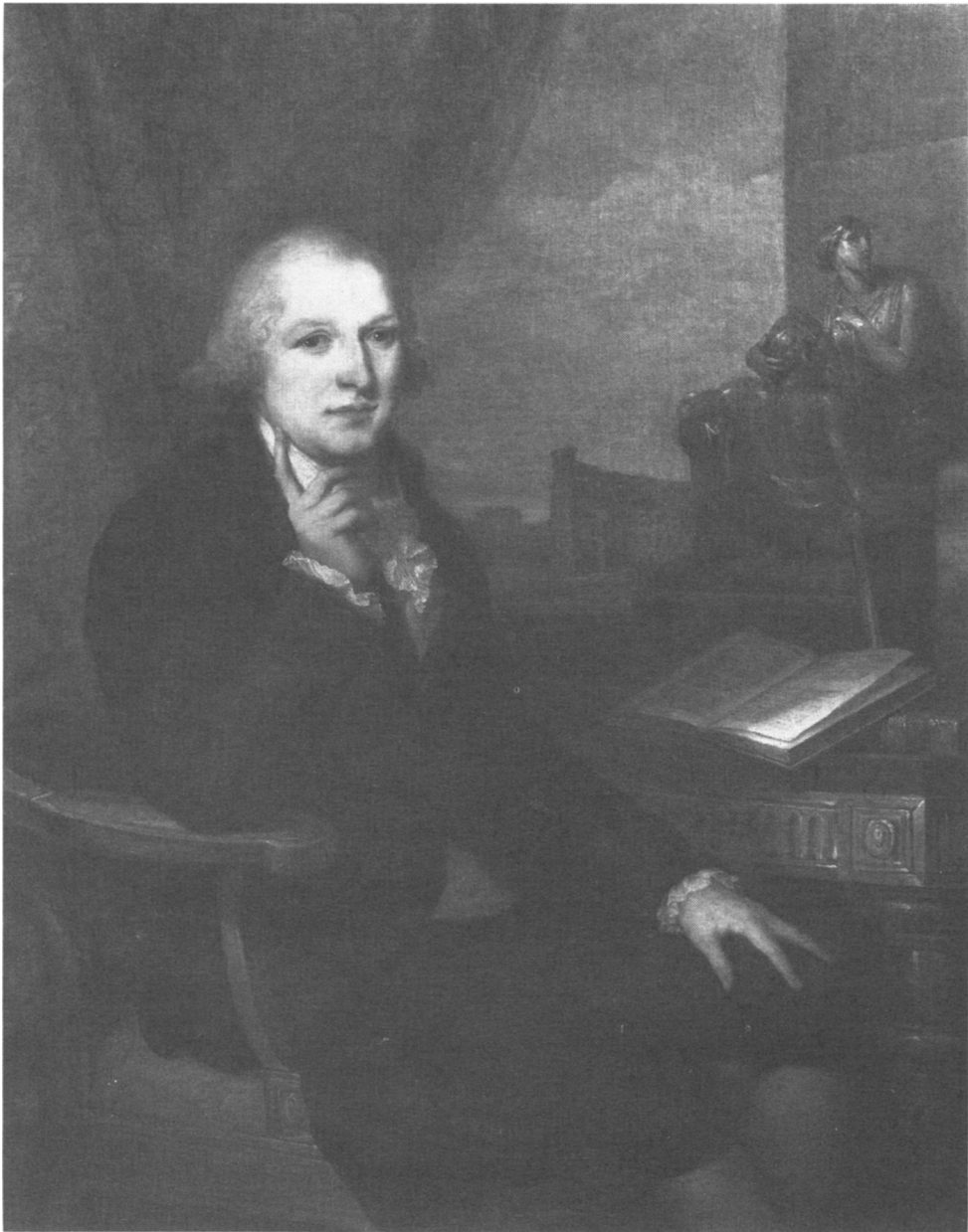


FIGURE 1. Angelica Kauffman, *Portrait of David Ker*, Rome, 1793 (David Ker collection, England) by kind permission of the owner.

Although her German admirers seemed to view her as the overworked victim of her husband, Kauffman's Italian biographer De Rossi presents a rather different view. According to him, the adoring Zucchi relieved Kauffman of all domestic duties so that she could devote her time to making art while he provided help and advice.¹³ In fact, as the records indicate, Zucchi ran the household and kept the accounts until his death in 1795, when her cousin took over the management of her domestic and business affairs.¹⁴ Zucchi may have profited from Kauffman's labors, but he also allowed her to enjoy the spotlight while he lived comfortably in the background.

My search for the woman behind the paintings, this astonishingly prolific artist, probably reveals as much as anything my desire to know how she could be so productive, maintain a comfortable household, keep up a large correspondence with a wide circle of male and female friends, manage to please her clients, and to amass a personal fortune large enough to leave substantial sums and costly objects to her numerous heirs. Somehow the image of the supportive husband rings true! I conclude with a quotation from Kauffman's Last Will and Testament: "As all I possess has been attained by my work and industry, having from earliest childhood devoted myself to the study of painting, so now I can dispose of the fruits of my industry as I will."¹⁵ A fitting end, indeed.

NOTES

1. Hester Lynch Piozzi, *Observations and Reflections* (London: A Strahan and T. Caldwell, 1789), 2:140–41.
2. See Wedny Wasssyng Roworth, *Angelica Kauffman: A Continental Artist in Georgian England* (London: Reaktion Books, 1992), 87ff.; and Anthony M. Clark, "Roma mi è sempre in pensiero," in *Studies in Roman Eighteenth-Century Painting*, ed. Edgar P. Bowron, (Washington, D.C.: Decatur House Press, 1981), 125–38.
3. "Memoire di spese fatta cominciando dalli 8 nov. 1782," British Museum Manuscript, Egerton, Z169.
4. F. Romagnoli, "Descrizione di tutto ciò che vi è rinvenuto nell'Abitazione dalla defonta Angelica Kauffman" Rome, 25 Jan. 1808, (Special Collections, Getty Center)
5. August von Kotzebue, *Erinnerungen von einer Reise aus Liefeland nach Rom und Neapel*, Berlin, 1805, in E. Thurnher, *Angelika Kauffmann und die deutsche Dichtung* (Bergenz: E. Ross, 1966), 187.
6. Kauffman's copy of the Rembrandt (Uffizi, Florence, 1643) is lost, but a 1762 drawing is preserved in a sketchbook in the Victoria and Albert Museum. The Reynolds portrait was engraved by Bartolozzi in 1781. Both are illustrated in Roworth, *Angelica Kauffman*, 19 and 41.
7. Romagnoli, "Descrizione," lists these and many more items.
8. Mss Royal Academy of Art, London, "Memoria delle pitture fatta d'Angelica Kauffman," 40. This appears in English translation as the "Memorandum of Paintings" in Victoria Alexandra Manners and George Charles Williamson, *Angelica Kauffmann, R. A.: Her Life and Works* (London: John Lane, 1924), 141–74.
9. "Memoria delle pitture," 40 (Manners and Williamson, 164)
10. "Memoria delle pitture," 41 (Manners and Williamson, 164). I am grateful to Mr. David Ker for information about the sitter and the Ker family and wish to acknowledge my indebtedness for information gleaned from Sir Brinsley Ford's Grand-Tour Archive at the Paul Mellon Centre for the Study of British Art, London.
11. Johann Wolfgang Goethe, *Italian Journey*, Rome, 18 Aug. 1787, in *Collected Works of Goethe*, trans. by R. R. Heitner (New York: Suhrkamp, 1989), 6:307.
12. Letter to Caroline Herder, 22 April 1789, in Thurnher, *Angelika Kauffmann*, 146.
13. G. G. De Rossi, *Vita di Angelica Kauffman* (Florence: A Spese di Molini, 1810), 85.
14. Wendy Wasssyng Roworth, "Angelica Kauffman's 'Memorandum of Paintings,'" *Burlington Magazine* 76 (1984): 629–30. Her cousin Johann Anton Kauffman became her chief heir.
15. Manners and Williamson, *Angelica Kauffmann*, 242.